DECONSTRUCTED PRODUCT STRATEGY

Ten years of Jio, *drawn as a metro map.*

One main line: the connection. Three branch lines tried to go beyond it. Not all of them still run.

KEY

- **Main line** · the SIM
- **Bundle** · put it inside the plan
- **Build** · make your own app
- **Buy** · rent what users want

MAIN LINE · THE CONNECTION

J

RIDE THE LINE →

STOP 01 · 2016

Price mattered. *The slot mattered more.*

Most Indian phones were dual-SIM. So nobody had to give up their number. They just filled the empty slot with a free Jio SIM. **About 100 million users in roughly 170 days.**

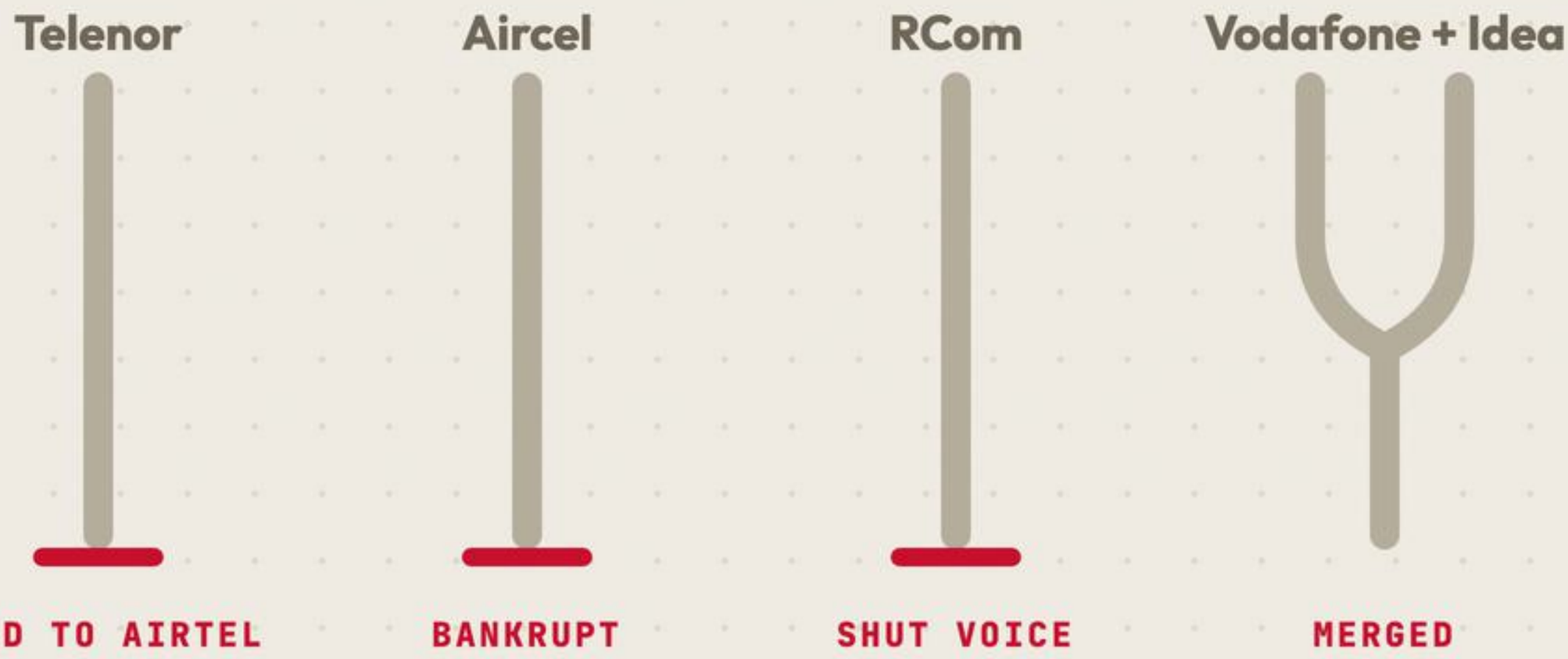


Rule 1 · slot into a habit that already exists

FREE SIM

About a dozen operators went in. *Three came out.*

With three players, matching a rival's tariff hike is the rational move. In July 2024 Jio raised prices 12–27%, lost ~10.9M connections, **and still made ~5% more.**



Rule 2 · pricing power came from market structure

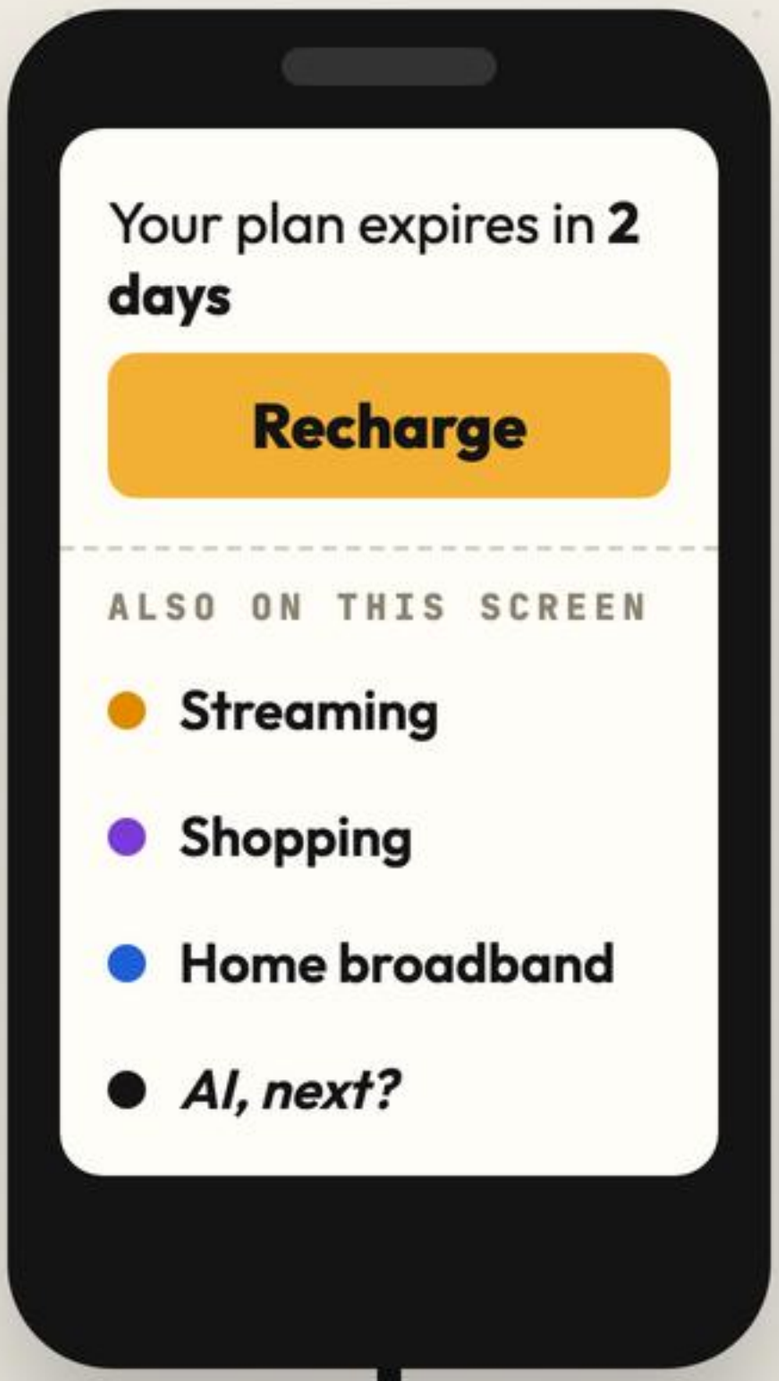
3 PLAYERS

STOP 03 · EVERY 28 DAYS

The busiest station isn't an app. *It's the recharge screen.*

About **90%** of Indian connections are prepaid. Plans expire every 28, 56 or 84 days, so users keep coming back to pay.

It isn't sold to anyone. *It's where everything else is sold.*



MYJIO

BUNDLE LINE · RIDE THE CONNECTION

Put it inside the plan, and it *mostly works.*

These win when the alternative is nothing: a 2G phone, no home broadband. The one flop was a smartphone that needed buyers to prefer it.

JioBharat	2023	WON
AirFiber	2023	WON
JioPhone Next	2021	FLOPPED
JioFiber	2019	MIXED
JioPhone	2017	WON
JioTV	2016	WON

Build a standalone app, and *the trains stop coming.*

> *Distribution gets an app installed. Only preference gets it opened again tomorrow.*

END OF LINE

- **JioMart** 2020 — MIXED
- **JioPages** 2020 — FLOPPED
- **JioMeet** 2020 — FLOPPED
- **JioChat** 2015 — FLOPPED

W

CHANGE HERE FOR WHATSAPP

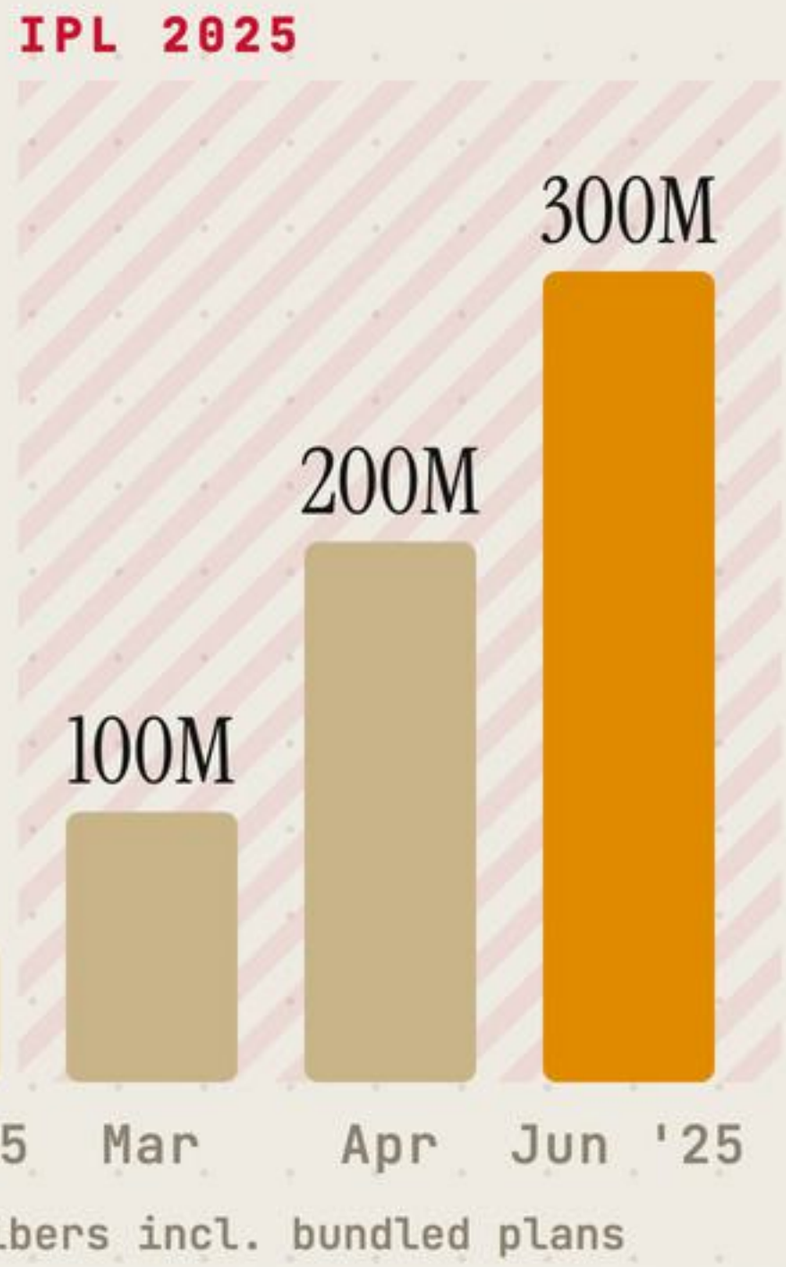
In 2020 Jio sold ~10% of itself to Meta, and JioMart launched inside WhatsApp, the messenger JioChat was built to rival. It stopped building habit and started renting it.

Buy something scarce, and *the platforms fill up.*

Music isn't scarce: every app licenses the same songs. Live IPL is in one place. Jio didn't build a reason to subscribe. **It bought one.**

JioHotstar
2023–25
WON

JioSaavn
2018
MIXED

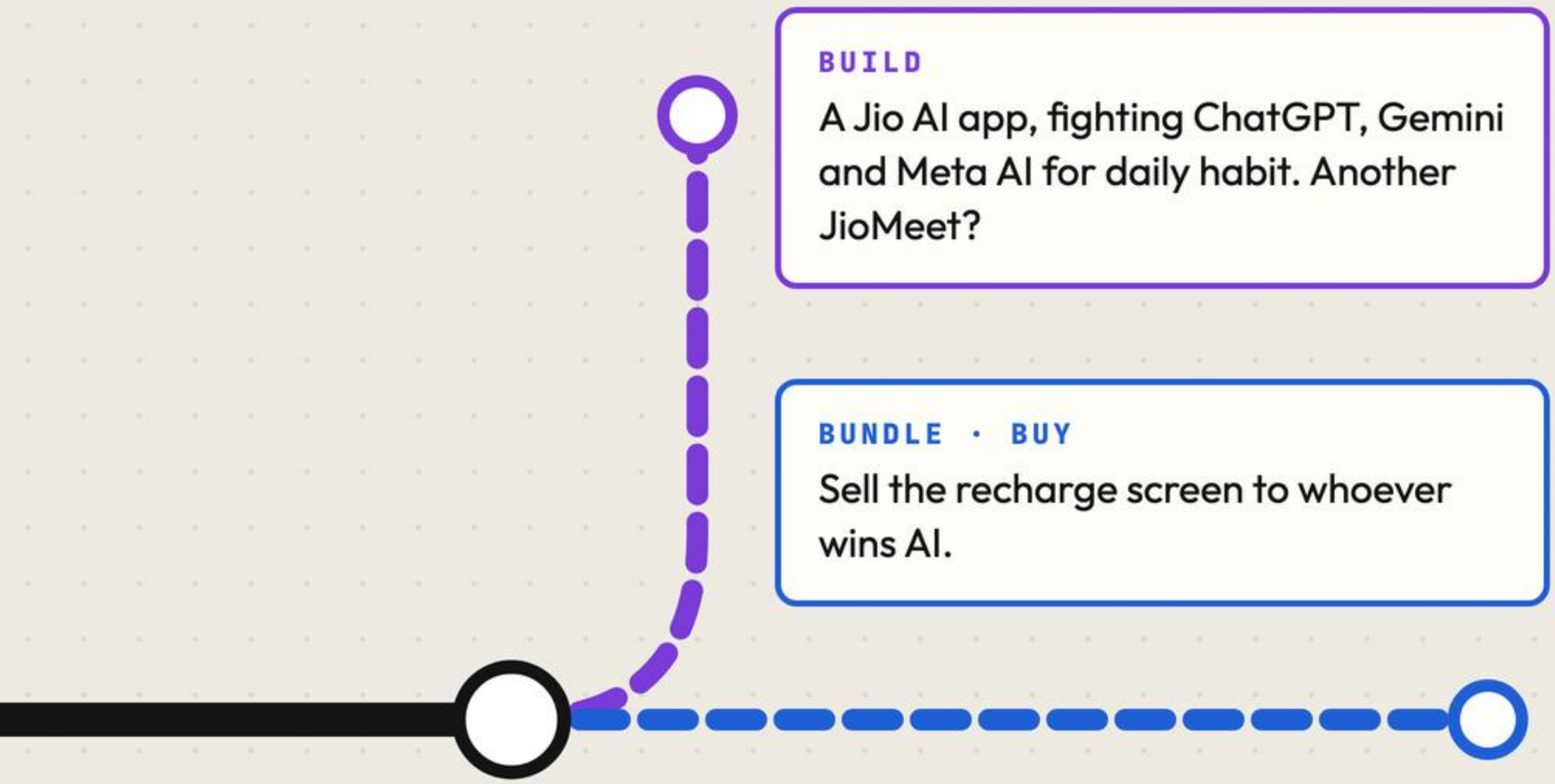


The line forks. *Which way does Jio go?*

THE ONE-LINE READ

Jio sells distribution *and buys preference.*

The telecom arm still earns ~95% of Jio's EBITDA. The market is pricing the main line.



FULL MAP · LINK IN COMMENTS ↓